

European Utilities: Hormuz re-opening: what to do with the sector

Why Utilities underperformance may continue a little longer. At the very start of the Middle East conflict, Utilities outperformed the broader markets as investors turned to defensive names and renewables (energy security, rising power prices). As expectations around the duration of the conflict rose, the market started to worry about rising interest rates and cost of capital; this led to a sector underperformance. A potential peace deal could temporarily prolong such an underperformance, as the market is likely to rotate into sectors more positively geared to a re-opening of the Strait of Hormuz, and as a sharp fall in commodities could affect IPPs and Renewable Developers. And yet, we think this underperformance is about to come to an end.

Why we think it is nearly a turning point for Utilities. We believe the sector could soon be “de-risked”, and we would look for entry points into an industry that, in our view, is undergoing a profound secular transformation, underpinned by five drivers: **(1) power demand** growth has turned positive since 2025 and is set to accelerate further, thanks to rising electrification, especially in retail, where heat pumps and electric vehicles continue to gain market share; **(2) datacenters** are coming to Europe, and we are now seeing growing evidence thanks to 20 GW under construction, already reaching FID or nearly fully authorized. With booming connection requests to the grid (our latest projection is at c.500 GW, or 1.5x EU’s consumption) and rising AI Agent adoption rates, datacenters could drive annual power consumption by 1.5–2% pa, as of 2028–29; **(3)** with rising power consumption and ageing infrastructure (power grids are 40 years old and power plant retirements are beginning to accelerate), we see a growing **electricity infrastructure deficit**, which is likely to boost returns, especially in renewables and FlexGen; **(4)** we estimate **investment needs** in European electrification of €2.5–3.5 trn (see here) over the coming ten years, depending on power demand; this compares to c.€1.5 trn over the past ten years; and **(5)** returns in **US renewables** are currently the highest in history, at c.10–11% project IRRs, and domestic activities keep trading at a major discount to replacement costs.

The earnings super-cycle. A growing electricity infrastructure deficit is likely to support higher returns in Renewables and FlexGen, as well as rising investment needs across the entire value chain – including power grids. For the main electrification compounders, this implies high single digit to low double digit average earnings growth into the 2030s, on our estimates (see here). This should support an earnings super-cycle, which is likely to lead to strong earnings revisions by 2030–31 and expanding multiples. This should also weaken the sector correlation with cost of

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capital and commodity prices.

Re-opening exposure: Enel (Buy rated, PT €12/sh). We note that Enel currently features the highest short interest in our coverage (source BBG). We believe lower bond yields and power prices would reduce the cost of capital and ease domestic regulatory pressure. We also believe that organic growth is under-appreciated: power grids are >40% of EBITDA and are projected to grow by 7-8% pa to 2030 (c.€650-800 mn EBITDA pa); Enel has also been ramping up organic growth in renewables, as the company is targeting +4 GW annual additions, equivalent to +c.€500 mn EBITDA pa, on GSe. Lastly, we note that Enel is bidding on 15 GW of US renewable assets. We estimate +7% EPS CAGR to 2030, well ahead of Bloomberg consensus. On a 2027E basis, Enel trades on a 12.5x P/E, a major discount vs peers.

US renewable exposure: RWE (Buy PT €68.5/sh) and EDPR (Buy, PT €17.5/sh). Strong power demand, lessened competition from the oil majors and rising equipment costs (re-shoring) continue to improve the outlook for pricing and returns in US renewables. Projected strength in power demand, potential upside from Agentic AI and constraints in the domestic supply chain suggest that this situation may persist for at least 3-5 years. This backdrop is particularly favourable for EDPR, in our view, where c.65% of EBITDA is from US renewables; the stock currently trades at c.€1.2 mn/MW, or around 50% below replacement value. We also note that RWE derives c.25-30% of its EBITDA from the US. We also believe that a pivot into power transmission (Amprion) could lead to better than anticipated EPS accretion, lower the cost of capital, and increase the share of domestic/low risk profits. Currently, RWE trades below our estimated value for operating assets (c.€59/sh).

Transformative electrification stories: Naturgy (Buy, PT €32.5/sh). Our positive stance rests on three reasons: (1) we see significant re-leveraging potential (c.€10-12 bn by 2030), which could drive mid to high single digit EPS growth to 2030; this compares to a flattish EPS evolution according to Bloomberg consensus, implying scope for 20-40% EPS upgrades by the end of the decade; (2) Naturgy's strategic pivot toward electricity activities could support longer-term organic growth as well as multiple expansion: the stock is currently trading on a 2027E P/E of less than 13x; and (3) near-term upside from LNG activities and domestic ancillary services suggests potential for an earnings beat and a likely 2026 guidance upgrade at first-half results in late July.

Valuation and key risks

Enel

Valuation methodology. Our 12-month price target of €12.0 is based: (1) 1/3 on our SOTP valuation of €12.9/share. We value the RES Business via a DCF using a 6.1% WACC and model capacity additions through 2034. We value the remaining businesses, thermal, hydro, networks, and retail (except for Iberia thermal, where we use a DCF with a c.7% WACC) using an average EV/EBITDA multiple of c.7.5x on 2027E EBITDA; and (2) 2/3 on a 2027E peer-based P/E multiple of 15.2x, a discount vs the sector +1 standard deviation and a major discount vs the current 2027E sector multiples. This implies a valuation of c.€11.8/share.

Key risks. (1) lower commodity/power prices (especially in Iberia and Italy); (2) lower

regulated network returns (especially in Italy); (3) lower retail margins in Italy and Iberia; (4) further introduction of regulatory measures that negatively impact profits; (5) higher country risk premia; and (6) sustained depreciation of LatAm.

RWE

Valuation methodology. Our 12-month price target of €68.5 is based: (1) 2/3 on our 2027E SOTP of €72.8. We value the FlexGen business at a target valuation multiple of 8x and the renewables business using a DCF based on a WACC of 6.1% and on capacity additions until 2035 with no terminal value; and (2) 1/3 on the value of existing assets, at €59.6. When valuing existing assets, based on an EV/IC model, we assume no future growth beyond 2026.

Key risks. (1) recession and falling power demand; (2) weaker-than-expected LNG and power prices; (3) higher sovereign interest rates; (4) weak execution in the renewable pipeline; and (5) GBP/USD depreciation.

EDPR

Valuation methodology. Our 12-month price target of €17.50 is based on: (1) 2/3 on our 2027E SOTP of €20.0/share (we value the core RES Business via a DCF using a 5.8% WACC and model capacity additions through to 2036, with an implied EV/EBITDA multiple of 15.4x) and; (2) 1/3 on our valuation of existing assets of €13/share. When valuing existing assets, we assume no growth beyond 2026. We use an EV/IC approach to derive the valuation of existing assets.

Key risks. (1) Potential delays in the electrification process in the US/Europe; (2) lower-than-expected capacity additions; (3) lower-than-expected power prices; (4) higher sovereign interest rates; (5) significant appreciation in foreign currencies (USD/BRL).

Naturgy

Valuation methodology. Our 12-month price target of €32.5 is based on: (1) a P/E valuation (2/3 weight) of €33.7/share, which uses a target P/E of 15.2x, a discount to 1 st dev above sector mid-cycle; and (2) a SOTP (1/3 weight) of €29.0/share.

Key risks. (1) lower-than-expected commodity and power prices; (2) higher sovereign interest rates; (3) worse-than-expected macroeconomic conditions; and (4) lower-than-expected EBITDA yield on new investments.

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